REBEL LEADERS / FIELD TOOL 01



AI Stalemate

THE PRODUCT MANAGER FIELD GUIDE

Make a credible case for the opportunity. Shape the next move with your lead.

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For you, the product manager

OPEN YOUR PRODUCT MANAGER LAB >

UNDERSTAND THE PRESSURE. WORK THE SITUATION. LEAVE WITH A MOVE.

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You see an opportunity. Your lead sees a cost.

You want your team to move forward with AI. Your lead developer is not convinced. Before the next conversation, get specific about the outcome you want and curious about the work they would carry.

Start with the outcome you own

What would improve for your customers or your team? Faster drafting is one possible means. Name the customer wait, repeated task, missed learning, or capacity problem you actually want to change.

Ask your lead what they would carry

Your lead is accountable for what ships: quality, maintainability, data boundaries, and review. Ask which part of your proposal adds work or risk. Their answer may reveal how to improve it.

Keep the event separate from your story

Your lead declined a trial using customer data. That is an observation. They are afraid of change is an interpretation. Take the observable event into the conversation and ask for their account.

Make a proposal they can help shape

Try: I want to reduce the full effort of accepted work. Where might AI help, and what would we need to protect? Give your lead authority over technical suitability and the acceptance bar.

> Your win: lead a worthwhile opportunity with your developer, then explain the decision to the organization with evidence.

Paint a future worth working toward.

Before asking your lead to try a tool, get clear about your own Why. Paint a future they can recognize, then invite them to improve the picture with you.

Name the improvement you care about

As the PM, which customer or team outcome makes this worth pursuing? Name the problem, who experiences it, and why you care. Connect the AI proposal to that outcome.

Paint a recognizable before and after

Optional: picture six months from now. What can the team do confidently? What is better for customers? What could responsible progress enable for the company, your lead, and you? One sentence for each is enough. Use the short vision prompts in Private Prep, then invite your lead to improve the picture.

Connect it to a shared stake

The company could gain a useful capability. The team could gain mastery and influence over its standards. Building something others trust could also create professional opportunities for both leaders.

Invite authorship

Ask your lead: What would responsible use look like here? What would you change in this picture? Let their judgment change the task, the conditions, and the approach.

Connect the picture to the next move

A vision gives the work direction. The next move makes it credible: clarify a concern, resolve permission or capacity, use existing evidence, or agree on one bounded test.

> Try: If we can find a responsible way to reduce repetitive work, we could give the team more time for the hard problems. We could help this company set a standard other teams trust, and create opportunities for both of us. I'd like us to shape that together. What would make it worth pursuing for you?

Make the concern workable.

When your lead raises a concern, ask what it means in this workflow. These questions help you turn the concern into a condition or change your proposal. Your lead owns technical suitability; you help make the investment and tradeoff explicit.

The quality is not good enough

Which checks or standards fail? Consider a smaller task, clearer acceptance criteria, repository conventions, automated tests, and human review. Keep the existing quality bar.

Reviewing it takes longer

Where does effort increase? Consider smaller changes, explicit author verification, and protected review time. Measure accepted work across the whole workflow rather than the first draft.

Our data or code cannot go into that tool

Which inputs and approvals are involved? Establish the permitted tool and input boundary with the approval owner. Synthetic or non-sensitive inputs may be an option; permission comes first.

It does not understand our codebase

Which context or conventions are missing? Consider explicit repository instructions, a known example, and a contained task. Check whether the available context actually supports that use.

We do not have capacity

What work would this replace, and who must review it? Ask the priority owner to protect time or decline the investment. Unplanned overtime is not the trial budget.

We tried it and it was worse

Which task, conditions, and result? Use that evidence. If a materially different use is proposed, name what changed and why another test would answer a useful question.

GitHub: Copilot best practices

Thoughtworks: reducing AI development friction

> The useful question is: Which condition would make this proposal workable, and who can decide it? Keep a specific no and an unsupported yes open to the same scrutiny.

Let's get ready to talk with your lead.

Take 5-10 minutes before you talk with your lead. These notes are yours. Get clear about your outcome and assumptions so you can arrive curious, with a proposal worth discussing.

What conversations have you and your lead already had, and where do things stand?

Use the request, words, or event you can describe. Be precise enough that the other person could recognize it.

What are you assuming about your lead's motives?

Name your interpretation of their motive. Hold it as a hypothesis rather than a fact.

What customer or team outcome are you trying to protect?

Describe the opportunity, cost, obligation, or outcome you carry. Product and Engineering can both have legitimate answers.

What evidence have you seen yourself?

Separate a concrete past result from a prediction about future use. An observed failure deserves attention; it does not settle every use case.

What would change your mind about this use of AI?

Name the evidence that could alter your view. A trial is not useful if neither side would reconsider anything.

What do you need to ask your lead to understand where they are?

Leave room for their actual account of the cost. Do not turn private preparation into a better argument for your original position.

> You can reflect without typing. Any private notes you type stay only in this open tab: they are not saved by the Lab or included in shared exports. Refreshing or leaving the Lab clears them.

Bring the rooms you're in into this room.

Your lead may not hear the revenue, customer, or operational consequences discussed with leadership. Share that context so the team can judge the opportunity with you.

Name the outcome and the consequence

Describe who benefits, what changes, and why timing matters. If a sponsor says each week costs $500,000, attribute the estimate and explain what is included.

Keep estimates open to examination

Separate an observed cost, a forecast, and a stakeholder's claim. Name who can validate the figure. Urgency helps prioritize an investment; the engineering and access requirements still need owners.

Make the opportunity shared

A team that establishes trustworthy practices could improve delivery and influence how the company works. Connect that possibility to learning, mastery, customer value, and professional opportunity for both leaders.

Make the investment explicit

Ask what capacity, platform work, training, or review would make progress responsible. Take the tradeoff to the person who owns priorities, then report a next move with an owner and date.

> Try together: The opportunity matters. Let's put the business case and the conditions for responsible delivery in one picture.

Make access a design decision.

Your lead's concern about an unprotected API is a concrete issue to resolve. Help identify the data owner, the access decision, and the evidence needed before connecting a new app to real systems.

Specify who can do what to which data

Map users or groups to application roles, allowed actions, and resource boundaries. Include joiners, movers, leavers, and ownership of access changes. New apps need a coherent access model across the relevant systems.

Verify permissions in the API

Microsoft Entra sign-in establishes identity. APIs also need the appropriate token, scope, role, and resource-level authorization checks. Hiding a button does not protect a route. Include tests where access must be denied.

Bound what an agent can do

Record which environment and data it can use, which credentials it receives, and whether it can read, write, run commands, or deploy. Name approval points, least-privilege boundaries, and a recovery owner.

Assign the decision and verification

Ask your lead and the security/data owners to define and verify these conditions. You can help protect their capacity and escalate missing decisions. A completed Lab form is not a security approval.

Microsoft: app roles and groups

Microsoft: verify API scopes and roles

OWASP: authorization checks

> A real prerequisite can change the next move: resolve the access model, restrict the environment, or pause this use until the required verification exists.

Match the responsibility with the capability.

Your team may be developing engineering skills while delivering important work. Help make training, pairing, review, and operating practices part of the investment.

Start with demonstrated capability

Can the developer explain the change, test permission boundaries, review a diff, debug a failure, and describe deployment and rollback? Prior roles and age do not establish these capabilities; practical evidence does.

Protect learning and qualified review

Use pairing, focused training, small changes, and a reviewer qualified for the risk. Ask developers to explain why the generated change is correct and how they checked it. Reserve time for learning and review.

Build a repeatable delivery practice

Clarify acceptance criteria, Git and review practices, testing, deployment ownership, and feedback. Scrum familiarity helps a team coordinate; secure engineering capability also needs deliberate practice and coaching.

Treat acceleration as conditional

DORA describes AI as amplifying the strengths and weaknesses of the surrounding delivery system. Small batches strengthen feedback and review. Record what this team needs for this use, then evaluate accepted work at its full cost.

NIST: Secure Software Development Framework

GitHub: responsible use of Copilot agents

DORA: working in small batches

DORA: AI-assisted development research

> Prepare first can be a productive decision. Name the training, pairing, review, or platform work, the owner, and the evidence that will show the team is ready.

Shape a worthwhile bet.

Invite your lead into about 30 minutes of shared design. Bring the outcome and make room for their conditions. Use existing evidence if it answers the question; ask for a trial when there is a useful uncertainty to resolve.

Pitch the problem and the hypothesis

Name the observed problem and evidence. Shape the ambition together. Write: If we try this approach, we expect this improvement because... Keep predictions separate from facts.

Bound the work

Name the work outcome, exact task, and work that is out of scope. Choose a comparator without AI and say why the task size, experience, and acceptance bar are comparable.

Set the permission boundary

Ask your lead to confirm the tool, model/version, permitted inputs, and approval owner. A leadership request does not grant permission to use an unapproved tool or sensitive inputs.

Protect quality and capacity

Ask your lead to define acceptance checks. Agree an effort budget, timebox, rabbit holes, and what work moves to protect author and reviewer time. If the priority decision belongs to someone else, take that tradeoff to them.

Agree on the bar beforehand

Predict a change against the comparator, with units. Separately agree the minimum worthwhile result across the full workflow and a stop rule. Record expected qualitative changes. A small test can support or challenge a belief without proving it universally.

Make ownership explicit

Name the task owner, reviewer, decision owner, and review date. Record whether they have accepted the bet; a brief does not create agreement. Export it before starting. If a prerequisite is missing, name it and choose PAUSE.

> Adapted from Ryan Singer's Shape Up (basecamp.com/shapeup). A missed target can teach you something useful. A bet never attempted has no result.

Count the work on both sides.

When the result comes back, ask about everyone's work. Count setup, verification, review, rework, and follow-up alongside drafting. You need accepted work at a defensible full cost to make a case to leadership.

Workflow stage	Without AI	With AI
Setup / context	10 min	15 min
Drafting	45 min	12 min
Author verification	15 min	25 min
Reviewer checking	15 min	30 min
Rework	5 min	15 min
Follow-up	0 min	0 min
Total person-minutes	**90 min**	**97 min**

A separate effort example

These fictional measurements describe one matched unit-test task. The acceptance bar passed after rework. Drafting was faster with AI, while verification, review, and rework increased.

What the totals establish

Drafting took 33 fewer minutes, but the full recorded workflow took 7 more. Reviewer checking increased by 15 minutes. The agreed effort bar was missed in this local test.

What remains outside the totals

Record acceptance checks, defects, reviewer experience, tool cost, elapsed time, first-use learning, and limits to comparability. Name an owner and date for a later defect check.

> A complete total is useful evidence. It is not a universal AI productivity claim, a quality verdict, or proof of causation.

Four legitimate next moves.

Review the evidence with your lead and the agreed decision owner. Explain what this particular test supports, what remains uncertain, and the next action you are asking the organization to support.

CONTINUE

The evidence supports this bounded use under these conditions. Record the operating boundaries and the next review. Continue does not mean AI everywhere.

REVISE

The use may have value, but the task, inputs, review workflow, or boundaries need to change. Name what will change before another approved trial.

STOP

The evidence does not support this use, or a guardrail was breached. Record why and preserve what was learned. There is no obligation to turn a failed use case into adoption.

PAUSE

A prerequisite, approval, owner, capacity, or useful evidence is missing. Name the prerequisite and who will resolve it. Pause can be chosen before a trial starts.

> Every decision needs a reason, the limits of the evidence, an accountable next-action owner, and a date. Record unresolved disagreement rather than claiming consensus.

A worthwhile opportunity. Preparation first.

Fictional case: your sponsor reports a costly delay. Your lead identifies unverified API permissions and gaps in the team's engineering practice. You bring both into one investment decision.

The business context

The sponsor estimates $500,000 per week in operational opportunity. The figure is not yet validated. The PM will clarify the assumptions with Finance. The team sees why the outcome matters.

The system and team prerequisites

Access roles and record boundaries across apps are unresolved. Routes need allowed/denied-access tests. Developers need pairing, qualified review, and practice explaining, testing, deploying, and rolling back a change.

The Shared Next-Step Brief

PREPARE FIRST. No production connection or agent write/deploy permissions. The data/security owner defines access policy. The engineering manager leads a supervised exercise. The PM protects capacity and validates the business assumptions.

The Decision Brief

PAUSE this proposed use. Review readiness next Tuesday, with access-test evidence and a demonstrated engineering workflow. Then decide whether an approved synthetic-data trial would answer a useful question.

The update to leadership

We propose preparation time to resolve access boundaries and build team readiness. This protects a worthwhile opportunity while making the conditions for responsible delivery explicit. No AI productivity result has been measured.

> They leave with a responsible investment and an accountable next move. The opportunity stays visible, and the prerequisites receive owners.

Take this into the work.

Use the Guide to prepare your judgment, then open your PM Lab to work the situation in front of you. Nic's walkthrough shows the same process on a realistic example.

1. Prepare privately

Open Private Prep in the PM Lab. Write what happened, your Why, the future you want to help create, and what you still need to ask your lead.

2. Understand each other and choose a move

Open Conversation. Share the outcome, ask what your counterpart is concerned about, and name what remains unresolved. Export the Shared Next-Step Brief as a proposal or an agreement. Clarifying, asking a specialist, preparing, reviewing evidence, testing, and stopping are all possible next moves.

3. Shape a Bet Brief when appropriate

Move to Shared Work. Agree on the task, comparator, permission, quality, capacity, bar, stop rule, owners, and review date. Export the Bet Brief before the test.

4. Return with evidence

Enter full-workflow effort for both methods, quality results, and comparison limits. Export the Evidence Record. Blank effort stays unknown.

5. Write the decision

Choose Continue, Revise, Stop, or Pause. A conversation or preparation decision can go straight to Decision without a trial. Name the reason, limits, next action, owner, date, and leadership update.

Keep what matters

Shared drafts stay in this browser on this device. Private reflection stays only in the open tab and is not saved or exported. Export shared work before changing devices. There is no cloud synchronization.

> Use Load Examples in each Lab step to see the expected kind of answer. It replaces only that step. Watch Nic work a realistic case to see how the thinking connects.